Imagine and OCD

By 'Kristen' and Neil Hilborn

INTRODUCTION

ADHD, OCD, or Asperger's syndrome - as children we are not educated on the humanity of those with mental disorders. We are simply told that they are different . . . special. As we grow older, they become a topic, a subject, an objectification . . . never a peer. We approach them as if they are fragile objects, so volatile that one wrong move can trigger a breakdown. We befriend them out of pity. We befriend them out of curiosity. We observe them from afar, analyze their ticks, hide our creeping superiority, or in some cases, disguise disgust as ignorance. We are never real with them. If only we could . . . Imagine by 'Kristen' (last name withheld by editor)

IMAGINE

Imagine getting dressed in the morning

Then realizing you did it "wrong",

And that you have to take off your clothes

And start over

And over

And over again . . . .

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Imagine having to tap your foot in a 16-beat pattern

While other people watch, half amused, half freaked out.

Imagine being forced to keep it going for hours

And hours

And even more hours . . .

Imagine becoming "stuck" in front of a mirror,

Staring at imperfections that no other human would notice,

Unable to move as the minutes tick by

And by

And by . . .

Imagine

Imagine being fired from work

Because of all these things you do --

Imagine being alienated from people around you

Because everyone thinks you're "weird" –

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Imagine dealing with this monstrous OCD until you die

Until you die

Until you die.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Vrinda Pendred (ed)
Book: Check Mates: A Collection of Fiction, Poetry and Artwork About Obsessive-Compulsive Disorder, by People with OCD
ISBN: 978-0956452900
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TRANSITION

But what happens when people with mental disorders get real with us? What happens when we find out that they feel just as we feel, and in the case of Neil Hilborn's poem OCD, are capable of expressing their feelings more beautifully than we could ever dream of?

Mental disorders are real. But humanity is real too. And if we cannot recognize the humanity in every single individual, regardless of their handicap, disorder, differences -- then we are the ones with a mental disorder, and it's more debilitating than ADHD, OCD, or Asperger's syndrome could ever be– it's a disease of apathy.

OCD by Neil Hilborn

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OCD

The first time I saw her

everything in my head went quiet.

All the ticks, all the constantly refreshing
images just disappeared.

When you have Obsessive Compulsive Disorder, you don't really get quiet moments.

Even in bed, I'm thinking:

Did I lock the doors? Yes.
Did I wash my hands? Yes.
Did I lock the doors? Yes.
Did I wash my hands? Yes.

But when I saw her, the only thing I could think about was the hairpin curve of her lips

or the eyelash on her cheek—
the eyelash on her cheek—
the eyelash on her cheek.

I knew I had to talk to her.

I asked her out six times in thirty seconds.

She said yes after the third one, but none of them felt right, so I had to keep going.

On our first date, I spent more time organizing my meal by color than I did eating, or fucking talking to her

But she loved it.

She loved that I had to kiss her goodbye sixteen times or twenty-four times if it was Wednesday.

She loved that it took me forever to walk home because there are lots of cracks on our sidewalk!

When we moved in together, she said she felt safe, like no one would ever rob us because I definitely locked the door eighteen times.

I'd always watch her mouth when she talked—
when she talked—
when she talked—
when she talked

when she said she loved me, her mouth would curl up at the edges.

At night, she'd lay in bed and watch me turn all the lights off, and on, and off, and on, and off, and on, and off, and on, and off, and on, and off.

She'd close her eyes and imagine that the days and nights were just passing in front of her.

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But some morning, I started kissing her goodbye but then she'd just leave because I was making her late for work.

When I stopped in front of a crack in the sidewalk, she just kept walking

When she said she loved me, her mouth was a straight line

She told me I was taking up too much of her time

Last week she started sleeping at her mother's place.

She told me that she shouldn't have let me get so attached to her; that this whole thing was a mistake, but,

How can it be a mistake when I don't have to wash my hands after I touch her?

Love is not a mistake, and it's killing me that she can run away from this and I just can't.

I can't go out and find someone new

Because I always think of her.

Usually, when I obsess over things, I see germs sneaking into my skin.

I see myself crushed by an endless succession of cars

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And she was the first beautiful thing I ever got stuck on.

I want to wake up every morning thinking about the way she holds her steering wheel

How she turns shower knobs like she opening a safe.

How she blows out candles—
blows out candles—
blows out candles—
blows out candles—
blows out—

Now, I just think about who else is kissing her.

I can't breathe because he only kisses her once—he doesn't care if it's perfect!

I want her back so bad,

I leave the door unlocked –

I leave the lights on.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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